Discussion Round Opening Stage

Mechanics and Structure

Over the course of 60 minutes, there are two primary components that make up a round of Discussion: procedural and substantive.

- **Procedural** components provide structure and order to the round, but do not directly contribute ideas or thoughts aimed at solving the task. Examples include setting an agenda, focusing the group, and timing.
- **Substantive** components provide ideas and thoughts in order to solve the task. These involve contributing research or anecdotal evidence, or synthesizing multiple viewpoints.

The initial stage of a Discussion round focuses on understanding the task and establishing the structure of the discussion. This stage is mostly procedural, as your group is first learning about the task, and trying to come up with a plan for how to solve the problem in the task.

This stage of the round generally has these mechanical elements:

1. Distributing the task
2. Reading the task
3. Analyzing the task
4. Clarifying the task
5. Setting an agenda or consensus question
6. Researching the task

Distributing the task

On Paper

The task is usually delivered by the judge. Some tournaments may release tasks ahead of time, but usually you won't know the task until your round starts. It is customary to have everyone start with the task face-down, then as a group you all turn the task over at the same time to read once everyone gets their copy. Your 60 minute round starts once the task is turned over. Please note that the judge receives a copy of the task as well.

Electronically

The task is published electronically, usually on a Google doc. Learn from your coach before the tournament how to access this document. Some tournaments will publish their tasks before the tournament begins. Some tournaments will publish their tasks early in the morning the day of. Many tournaments will publish the task for that round approximately when the round is to start.

No matter when the task is released, your group should wait for the judge and all the students to be ready before starting the round.

However, if you receive a task before the round, try to do your Task Analysis and Research before the round starts. In this scenario, you could attempt to skip the 5 minute timed research held within the round by suggesting to the group that since the task came out before the round, you assume everyone has had a chance to do their research. Back down from this suggestion quickly if some members of your round haven't done their research yet. But making the suggestion will usually favor you in the judge's opinion, because the judge often will question why the group has to hold research in the round when a task was released early.

Reading the task

Often, groups will have a member read the task aloud. I advise to try and persuade the group to read silently in most situations*. The students who want to read the task aloud are typically the ones trying to control the mechanics of the round. They believe that by grabbing this first point of control, the rest of the group will begin looking to them as the leaders, and be less resistant to them later imposing agendas and timing. Don't let them get away with this! Speak up and suggest that we all can read the task just as well as they can, and by everyone reading independently, you can move straight into clarifications. However, if they resist, back down quickly, and state that if it helps others, then that's fine. What this does is to establish yourself as a leader, as well as demonstrate to the judge that you think critically about in-round mechanics. If you prolong this argument, though, it can backfire (the judge may think you're losing time if this turns into a long argument). If a task is read aloud, make sure you highlight, underline, circle the WHO, WHAT, HOW, WHERE, and SEARCH TERMS in the task during the recitation, so no more time is lost before moving into Clarifications.

** One situation where reading the task aloud is beneficial is when you have an audience. Most preliminary discussion rounds won't have audience members; final rounds typically will have an audience. If you find that you are in a round with audience members, then please go ahead and read the task out loud for their benefit.*

Analyzing the task

While reading the task, you also need to analyze the task so you are ready to make meaningful contributions during Clarifications. As a part of task analysis, you need to identify, and highlight these key details from your task:

WHO

Who does the task ask you to become? What role are you playing? Does this role have any power to make changes, or does the role merely advise others?

WHAT

What problem(s) are you trying to solve? Make sure you separate this from HOW you are going to solve the problem (next bullet). Sticking to the problem statement you are trying to solve will help you keep your group on task!

HOW

How will your group solve the problem? Are there specific actions the task says you need to perform (creating task lists, pros/cons, make a presentation, etc.)?

WHERE

Where does the task originate from, and where does it take place? Knowing the setting can often help you quickly identify the major section from your bibliography in which you can find relevant research (e.g. domestic vs. international, governmental vs. individual, etc).

SEARCH TERMS

In addition to the above, most tasks will have a lot of background details, where facts and figures are often cited. Highlight keywords from the background to use as search terms when conducting your research. Especially look for keywords that are repeated. If there are specific articles cited from newspapers, magazines, or an online publication, highlight these and see if they are in your research file. If not, make a note of this source and add it to your research later (so you can use it in the future).

Sometimes tasks begin with the abbreviations from the Discussion outline (eg. II.B) which can also be used to help you narrow down where you look for relevant materials. Use the structure of your shared research document to quickly navigate to the articles within that section of the outline.

Template For Task Analysis

Use this template to help you write down notes while analyzing your task:

Category	Description	Task-Specific Analysis (Fill in details)
WHO	Who does the task ask you to become? What role are you playing? What power does this role have?	
WHAT	What problem(s) are you trying to solve? Sticking to this helps you **Focus the Group**.	
HOW	How will your group solve the problem? Are there specific actions or deliverables required (e.g., plan, pros/cons, presentation)?	
WHERE	Where does the task originate, and where does it take place? (Helps identify relevant research area, e.g., domestic/global).	
TERMS	Highlight keywords from the task background to use as search terms. Look for repeated terms or specific organizations/dates.	

Example from Previous Practice Task

Mental health issues have long been stigmatized in the United States and most of the world. While this problem has decreased over time, it is still far too prevalent for many who suffer from these illnesses. You are members of the American School Counselor Association, meeting at their national convention to discuss more active methods to combat mental illness. Your goal is to examine what effects the stigmatization of mental illness still has on K-12 students and craft a plan which can be implemented by counselors at their schools to support these children.

Here is the analysis of the task:

Category	Analysis
WHO	**Members of the American School Counselor Association.** The group serves an advisory/implementation role, tasked with crafting a plan that counselors can implement at their schools.
WHAT	The core problem being solved is the **effects the stigmatization of mental illness still has on K-12 students**.
HOW	The group must achieve two specific deliverables: 1) **Examine** the effects of stigma on K-12 students, and 2) **Craft a plan** for counselors to implement to support these children.
WHERE	The discussion is taking place at the **national convention**. The implementation of the plan takes place in **K-12 schools**.
TERMS	American School Counselor Association, stigmatize, mental health, effects on K-12 students

Clarifying the task

Also known as “Clarifications”. Following the reading of the task, most groups go into a clarifications period, where the group tries to get to consensus on what the task means. If you have used your reading time to highlight the WHO, WHAT, HOW, WHERE, you will be able to jump into clarifications and help answer many of the questions that others may have. You should offer suggestions during clarifications around what kinds of actions you’re supposed to take, how you might ensure you can stay on task, and in general help answer any questions that others might have. This is arguably the most important phase to each discussion round, and should be the first thing that is always performed after reading the task. Having your group all agree to, and fully understand what the task asks you to discuss first, will set you up for success. See also Re-clarification, below.

Setting an agenda

An agenda attempts to set time limits and/or an outline to the round. Agendas are typically proposed early in the round, and should ideally use the task as the source of the outline. Agendas set before Clarifications are not effective at managing the round, and are made by overly aggressive “project manager” discussants to score early praise from the judge.

You will find that overly aggressive students who set agendas, and try to control the mechanics of the round tend to do very well in preliminary rounds at most invitational tournaments. This shifts in final rounds, as well as at MSHSL (eg Sections and State), and Conference tournaments, which by then contain a lot of these same aggressive students, and more experienced judges. Usually those more aggressive students will have a tougher time controlling the final round, and students who are good listeners, and unifiers tend to do better later. You will have to learn to take charge in early rounds, and then switch tactics to be more conciliatory and more of a supporter who can take lots of facts from everyone, add your own facts, synthesize, and summarize.

Example agenda

Here again is the same example task:

*Mental health issues have long been stigmatized in the United States and most of the world. While this problem has decreased over time, it is still far too prevalent for many who suffer from these illnesses. You are members of the American School Counselor Association, meeting at their national convention to discuss more active methods to combat mental illness. Your goal is to **examine** what effects the stigmatization of mental illness still has on K-12 students and **craft a plan** which can be implemented by counselors at their schools to support these children.*

From the task analysis, we determined the HOW was broken down into 2 deliverables:
1) **Examine** the effects of stigma on K-12 students, and
2) **Craft a plan** for counselors to implement to support these children.

Here is an agenda using these two HOWs as its structure:

Time (Suggested)	Agenda Item	Focus (How the group proceeds)
10 min	**Background (possibly Re-clarifications):** Share relevant research on the effects of mental illness stigma, citing sources.	Substantive Contribution
15 min	**Phase 1: Examination and Diagnosis:** Identify 2–3 major negative effects of mental health stigma on K-12 students.	Substantive Contribution
15 min	**Phase 2: Plan Crafting:** Brainstorm potential components of a plan counselors could implement, weighing options and contributing insights.	Substantive Contribution
5 min	**Phase 3: Synthesis and Consensus:** Reach consensus on the final plan recommendations.	Procedural/Substantive Contribution
5 min	**Final Summary: Summarize Findings** of the examination and the contents of the crafted plan.	Procedural Contribution

Consensus Question: An Agenda Alternative

When a task has very clearly defined a set of deliverables to follow, you could propose an alternative to the agenda. Known as a “consensus”, “leading”, or “unifying” question, this is a sophisticated competitive tactic used by effective discussants late in the season. This approach successfully leverages the core structure of the task while sidestepping the tactical pitfalls associated with poorly proposed agendas.

Based on the structure of the sources, this strategy functions as a powerful, high-level **procedural contribution** that focuses the group on the required **substantive** output.

The Structure of the "Consensus Question"

The effectiveness of this question stems from its direct integration of the essential elements of the task, as defined in your practice materials:

- **Based on the WHAT (The Problem):** The task analysis requires you to identify the **WHAT**—what problem(s) the group is trying to solve. The question must encapsulate this central problem (e.g., "Given the rise of economic fragmentation, are the proposed policies sufficient to ensure equitable prosperity?"). Focusing on the **WHAT** is crucial for reminding the group to keep the discussion on topic later in the round (known as **Focus the Group**).
- **Guided by the HOW (The Deliverables):** The question also incorporates the **HOW**—the specific actions or deliverables the task requires (e.g., crafting a plan, weighing pros/cons, making recommendations). When a task includes "strong deliverables," the question provides a clear metric for group success, forcing the group to work toward the required output defined by the task.

Countering Aggressive Agenda Setting

This tactic is particularly valuable because it counters the actions of "overly aggressive discussants" who attempt to take early control of the round.

- **The Flaw in Early Agendas:** Agendas proposed too early, especially before Clarifications, are less effective at managing the round and are often used solely to score early praise from the judge.
- **The Advantage of the Question:** By proposing a high-level question *instead* of a rigid, time-bound agenda, you can shift the procedural focus from dictating *timing* (which a traditional agenda does) to defining the **final goal of success**. This allows the group to remain flexible while maintaining focus on the desired **consensus** and **problem solving**.
- **Strategic Timing:** Students who are **good listeners, and unifiers** tend to do better in later, more competitive rounds. A competitor who proposes a question that focuses on the **consensus** outcome rather than dictating the initial flow demonstrates a more

conciliatory and unifying approach, which is often favored by more experienced judges late in the season.

In essence, this tactic is a way to set the **criterion for success** immediately after **Clarifications** (the most important phase), thereby framing the rest of the 60 minutes toward the final synthesis and summary, skills which are essential for success in later rounds.

Using this question is like defining the bullseye before the round even starts; while a traditional agenda tries to dictate *how* everyone throws their darts, the consensus question just makes sure everyone agrees on what they are aiming for.

Example of Consensus Question

The goal of coming up with a consensus question is to draft a single question that the group can use at the end of the round to determine if they successfully met the deliverables (HOW) and solved the problem (WHAT). This question serves as the definition of consensus. Essentially, a good consensus question can start with this phrase:

By the end of this discussion, will the group agree that we have... (Draft your success criterion here, based on the WHAT and HOW analysis above) ?

Using the same task from earlier in the Setting An Agenda and Task Analysis:
Mental health issues have long been stigmatized in the United States and most of the world. While this problem has decreased over time, it is still far too prevalent for many who suffer from these illnesses. You are members of the American School Counselor Association, meeting at their national convention to discuss more active methods to combat mental illness. Your goal is to examine what ***effects the stigmatization of mental illness still has on K-12 students*** *and* ***craft a plan*** *which can be* ***implemented by counselors*** *at their schools to support these children.*

A unifying question could be:

By the end of this discussion, will the group agree that we have crafted a plan which counselors could implement at K-12 institutions to support students impacted by the negative effects of mental health stigmatization?

Research

This is a phase of the round, typically 5 minutes in length, in which each person reviews their sources for relevant material to bring into the discussion. Use the task to guide you in finding relevant sources from your Discussion Facts document. Take note of the sources you want to use, and be ready to verbally cite them during the discussion; a good verbal citation includes publisher, date, and, if possible, author or title.

Rely particularly on the Search Terms you identified from your Task Analysis. Is there confusing terminology that needs to be defined? Can you identify the section of the outline this task was written from and find relevant articles from your shared research document to use as evidence?

Also rely on the HOW of the Task Analysis to guide what to research. If the task is asking the group for a list of pros vs cons, then try to research both positive and negative aspects of your problem statement. If there are more than a single HOW, make sure you have research that can apply to each of the deliverables as these should form the structure for your round, and ensure that you can make contributions throughout the remainder of the round.

Background

Immediately following the timed research, the group usually holds what is called a “background” period. This is a portion of time dedicated to just sharing what you all learned during the research phase. This tends to bleed into the Re-clarifications (see below) and the general discussion, so be particularly judicious on what you share here. General terminology definitions and research that helps clarify points of the agenda you may have been struggling with earlier in Clarifications are generally good to share right away. If you have research that is clearly helpful for a later phase of the discussion, try to hold back that research and use it later when you’ve reached that part of the round.

Re-clarification

See Clarification, above. This is a repetition of the initial Clarification phase, but held after Clarifications and Research phases. Re-clarifications are not always required, and when possible, should be avoided. Instead, use the time to review what everyone learned from their Research phase, and move into the discussion as quickly as you can to avoid time running off on re-analyzing the task. Having said that, though, always make sure you bring the group back to the task throughout the rest of the discussion, reminding them to keep their focus on what you all agreed to during Clarifications.